

CSC 113: Introduction to Programming in Python

Fall 2026 · Second Session (10 weeks) · Mon Oct 5 – Fri Dec 11, 2026 · 3 credit hours

Instructor	Prof. Alex Chen
Email	achen@example.edu
Office	Engineering Building II, Room 2240
Office hours	Tuesdays 3:00–5:00 PM and Thursdays 10:00–11:00 AM; virtual hours Sunday 7:00–8:00 PM
Class meetings	Tue / Thu 11:45 AM–1:00 PM (lecture), Fri 9:00–10:50 AM (lab), Engineering Building II 1011
Teaching assistants	Marcus Lee and Sofia Alvarez — lab support and code reviews
Prerequisite	None. Comfort with high-school algebra is helpful.

Course description

A first course in programming for students with no prior experience. You will learn to solve problems by writing clear, well-tested Python programs: variables and expressions, decisions, loops, functions, lists and dictionaries, files, exceptions and an introduction to classes. Weekly labs give hands-on practice, and three projects build toward a program of your own design.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this course you will be able to:

- Break a problem into steps and express them as an algorithm.
- Write, run and debug Python programs that use conditionals, loops and functions.
- Choose appropriate data structures (lists, tuples, dictionaries, sets) for a task.
- Read and write files and handle errors with exceptions.
- Test programs systematically and write readable, documented code.

Required materials

- Think Python, 3rd edition, by Allen B. Downey (free online)
- A laptop with Python 3.12+ and VS Code installed (setup guide on the course website)
- A free GitHub account for submitting projects

Grading

Component	Weight
Weekly labs (9, lowest dropped)	20%
Project 1: Text adventure	10%
Project 2: Data analyzer	10%
Final project	20%
Midterm exam	15%
Final exam	20%
Participation	5%
Total	100%

Grading scale: A 90–100 · B 80–89 · C 70–79 · D 60–69 · F below 60. Final grades are not curved; scores are rounded to the nearest whole percent.

Major project

Final project — design and build a Python program of your choice (a game, a budgeting tool, a data visualizer). It must use functions, at least one dictionary or class, file input/output and error handling. Deliverables: a proposal, a working prototype checkpoint and the final code with a README.

Course schedule

The schedule may change with notice; changes will be announced in class and on the course website.

Week	Dates	Topics	Due this week
1	Oct 5 – Oct 9	What is programming? Variables, types and expressions	Tue Oct 6: Lab 1 (Hello, Python)
2	Oct 12 – Oct 16	Strings, input and output	Tue Oct 13: Lab 2 (Strings and formatting)
3	Oct 19 – Oct 23	Booleans and conditional statements	Tue Oct 20: Lab 3 (Decisions)
4	Oct 26 – Oct 30	Loops: while and for; Project 1 due	Tue Oct 27: Lab 4 (Loops) Fri Oct 30: Project 1: Text adventure
5	Nov 2 – Nov 6	Functions, parameters and return values; midterm	Tue Nov 3: Lab 5 (Functions) Thu Nov 5: Midterm exam
6	Nov 9 – Nov 13	Lists, tuples and common list algorithms	Tue Nov 10: Lab 6 (Lists) Thu Nov 12: Final project proposal
7	Nov 16 – Nov 20	Dictionaries and sets; Project 2 due	Tue Nov 17: Lab 7 (Dictionaries) Fri Nov 20: Project 2: Data analyzer
8	Nov 23 – Nov 27	Files and exceptions (No class Wed Nov 25 – Fri Nov 27: Thanksgiving break)	Tue Nov 24: Lab 8 (Files and exceptions) Tue Nov 24: Final project checkpoint (working prototype)
9	Nov 30 – Dec 4	Introduction to classes and objects; final project due	Tue Dec 1: Lab 9 (Classes) Fri Dec 4: Final project due
10	Dec 7 – Dec 11	Review and final exam	Tue Dec 8: Final exam

Important dates and deadlines

Date	Item	Type	Time
Tue, Oct 6, 2026	Lab 1 (Hello, Python)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Oct 13, 2026	Lab 2 (Strings and formatting)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Oct 20, 2026	Lab 3 (Decisions)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Oct 27, 2026	Lab 4 (Loops)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Fri, Oct 30, 2026	Project 1: Text adventure	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Nov 3, 2026	Lab 5 (Functions)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Thu, Nov 5, 2026	Midterm exam	Exam	in class
Tue, Nov 10, 2026	Lab 6 (Lists)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Thu, Nov 12, 2026	Final project proposal	Project milestone	11:59 PM
Tue, Nov 17, 2026	Lab 7 (Dictionaries)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Fri, Nov 20, 2026	Project 2: Data analyzer	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Nov 24, 2026	Lab 8 (Files and exceptions)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Nov 24, 2026	Final project checkpoint (working prototype)	Project milestone	11:59 PM
Tue, Dec 1, 2026	Lab 9 (Classes)	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Fri, Dec 4, 2026	Final project due	Assignment due	11:59 PM
Tue, Dec 8, 2026	Final exam	Exam	in class

Course policies

Late work and make-ups. Labs and projects lose 10% per day late, up to 3 days. You have three “grace days” for the semester that waive the penalty — no explanation needed. Exams cannot be made up without documentation.

Academic integrity. All work you submit must be your own. You may discuss ideas with classmates, but written work, code and solutions must be produced individually unless an assignment says otherwise. Using AI tools to generate submitted work is not allowed unless the assignment explicitly permits it; when it is permitted, you must say how you used it. Suspected violations are reported to the Office of Student Conduct.

Accessibility. Students who need accommodations should contact Disability Resources as early as possible and share their accommodation letter with the instructor. All course materials are available in accessible formats on request.

Attendance. Regular attendance is expected and strongly linked to success in this course. If you must miss class, review the posted slides and notes and contact a classmate or the instructor. Absences for illness, religious observance or university-sanctioned events are excused with notice.

Communication. Course announcements are posted on the course website. Email the instructor from your university account and include the course code in the subject line; expect a reply within one business day.

Wellness. Your health matters more than any deadline. If you are struggling, reach out early — the Counseling Center, Academic Success Center and your academic advisor are all free resources.

Getting help

Come to office hours early and often — you do not need a specific question. Free campus resources:

- Academic Success Center — free tutoring and study-skills coaching, drop-in or by appointment
- Writing Center — one-on-one help at any stage of a writing project
- Counseling Center — confidential support for stress, anxiety and other concerns
- Library Research Help — chat, email or in-person help finding and citing sources